SPECIAL REMARKS BY HIS EXCELLENCY, SENATOR KASHIM SHETTIMA, GCON, VICE PRESIDENT OF THE FEDERAL REPUBLIC OF NIGERIA, AT THE 3RD INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE AND GOLDEN JUBILEE CELEBRATION OF THE CHARTERED INSTITUTE OF STATISTICIANS OF NIGERIA (CISON)

Theme: *"From Legacy to Leadership: 50 Years of Promoting Statistical Development in Nigeria"*

Protocol.

Distinguished Fellows and Members of the Chartered Institute of Statisticians of Nigeria, representatives of our international statistical community, members of the diplomatic corps, distinguished academics, captains of industry, ladies and gentlemen.

It is a pleasure to join you as we celebrate fifty years of a professional journey that began with the Nigerian Statistical Association and has matured into the Chartered Institute of Statisticians of Nigeria.

Fifty years is a remarkable milestone. It represents five decades of intellectual labour, professional commitment and an enduring belief that a nation must understand itself before it can transform itself.

I congratulate the Governing Council, Fellows and Members of CISON for this Golden Jubilee. Your theme, "From Legacy to Leadership," captures an important national imperative: Nigeria must move from merely collecting information to commanding the intelligence that drives national development.

As the saying goes, you cannot navigate an unfamiliar road with confidence if you refuse to consult the map. And in public administration, statistics is that map. It tells us where we are, how far we have travelled, and whether the destination we have chosen remains within reach.

STATISTICS: THE ARCHITECTURE OF GOOD GOVERNANCE

Distinguished guests, statistics is not an **ornamental** feature of governance. It is its operating system.

When President Bola Ahmed Tinubu embarked on difficult economic reforms, the objective was not simply to alter fiscal arrangements, exchange-rate mechanisms or the structure of public expenditure. The larger ambition was to establish a more productive, resilient and prosperous Nigerian economy.

Achieving that ambition requires reliable evidence. We must know where poverty is concentrated, which industries are creating productive jobs, which interventions are improving learning, where maternal mortality remains stubbornly high, and which infrastructure investments generate the greatest economic returns.

Without credible statistics, government risks confusing expenditure with achievement, activity with productivity, and political declarations with measurable progress.

A government that cannot measure its results cannot reliably improve them.

This is why the work of statisticians matters not only to ministries, departments and agencies, but also to businesses deciding where to invest, banks assessing risk, farmers planning production, and families making decisions about their livelihoods.

CONFRONTING NIGERIA'S STATISTICAL CHALLENGES

We must, however, acknowledge the distance Nigeria still has to travel.

First, our population data require urgent attention. Nigeria's last national population census was conducted in 2006. Two decades without a new census leave policymakers heavily dependent on **estimates and projections**. Population figures affect constituency planning, schools, hospitals, housing, infrastructure and the equitable distribution of resources. We must work towards a credible, professionally conducted census supported by transparent methodology and public confidence.

Second, our data remain fragmented. Federal agencies, state governments, local governments and private institutions often collect information using different classifications, definitions, systems and reporting schedules. The result can be duplication, gaps and conflicting figures. We need interoperable systems, common standards and clear institutional responsibilities.

Third, the informal economy remains difficult to measure adequately. Millions of Nigerians earn their livelihoods through small businesses, informal trade, household enterprises, artisanal production and subsistence agriculture. If these activities are poorly captured, we risk underestimating economic contribution and designing policies that overlook the very people who need them most.

Fourth, **agricultural** statistics need greater precision and frequency. In a country where food security, rural livelihoods and inflation are closely connected, reliable data on crop yields, cultivated land, livestock, storage, losses and market prices are indispensable. Better information can help **anticipate** shortages and direct support to the right locations.

Fifth, timeliness and public trust matter. Statistics that arrive too late may describe yesterday's problem while government is already making tomorrow's decisions. Methodological revisions, and unexplained discrepancies can also undermine confidence. Our statistical institutions must be independent in their professional judgement, transparent in their methods and accountable for the quality of their outputs.

Finally, we must strengthen statistical literacy. Data are not useful merely because they exist. Citizens, executives, legislators and public servants must understand what indicators mean, what they omit and what conclusions they can reasonably support.

These challenges are not indictments of the dedicated professionals who work in our statistical system. They are a call to equip those professionals with better institutions, technology, funding and authority.

BIG DATA AND ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE: THE NEW EXECUTIVE IMPERATIVE

Distinguished ladies and gentlemen, we have entered an era in which the competitive advantage of nations will increasingly depend on their ability to turn data into decisions.

Big Data, properly understood, is not simply a large volume of information. It is the ability to combine diverse, rapidly generated datasets and extract insights that conventional methods may miss.

Artificial intelligence is accelerating this possibility.

Imagine a government that can combine food prices, weather forecasts, road conditions, satellite imagery and agricultural output data to anticipate food shortages before they become a national emergency.

Imagine a health system that analyses disease surveillance, hospital attendance and medicine stocks to identify emerging outbreaks and move essential supplies before hospitals become overwhelmed.

Imagine a state government using population movements, school enrolment, transport flows and housing information to determine where new classrooms, clinics and roads are most urgently needed.

For business executives, the implications are equally profound. Data can improve demand forecasting, detect fraud, identify profitable customers, optimise inventories, anticipate supply-chain disruptions and reveal opportunities invisible to intuition alone.

The executive lesson is straightforward: data must move from the back office to the boardroom. Statistical insight should shape investment, budgeting, risk management and

performance assessment—not merely decorate reports after decisions have already been taken.

But we must also be prudent. Artificial intelligence cannot manufacture truth from unreliable information. Poor-quality data can produce sophisticated errors at unprecedented speed. Our systems must therefore protect privacy, cybersecurity, confidentiality and the rights of citizens. Human expertise and professional accountability must remain central.

A MODEL NIGERIA CAN EMULATE

One useful example is Singapore.

Through its whole-of-government approach to data and digital transformation, Singapore connects information across public institutions to improve planning and service delivery. Its GovTech agency supports shared digital infrastructure, analytics and AI tools, enabling agencies to make decisions based on actual needs rather than isolated institutional assumptions.

The application is practical: demographic information informs housing provision; healthcare utilisation helps forecast demand; and population movement data supports transport planning.

Nigeria need not copy Singapore's institutions wholesale. Our population, federal structure and development challenges are different. But we can adapt the underlying principle: one government, interoperable data, shared standards and decisions driven by evidence.

We will progressively build a secure national data ecosystem that allows authorised institutions to exchange appropriate information while protecting citizens' privacy. We will strengthen the National Bureau of Statistics, improve state statistical agencies, digitise administrative records and develop carefully governed partnerships with universities, research institutions and responsible private-sector data providers.

The goal is not to collect data for its own sake. It is to make government more anticipatory, investment more productive and public services more responsive.

A CHALLENGE TO CISON: FROM PROFESSIONAL RECOGNITION TO NATIONAL TRANSFORMATION

As we celebrate fifty years, I challenge the Governing Council, Fellows and Members of CISON to think beyond the celebration and towards the next fifty years.

First, establish a National Statistical Excellence Compact with measurable priorities for professional standards, data quality, institutional coordination and statistical literacy.

Second, develop a credible professional development programme in modern statistical methods, data engineering, machine learning, AI-assisted analysis, geospatial statistics and data ethics. Nigeria needs statisticians who can lead in the emerging data economy, not merely observe it.

Third, build stronger bridges between government, academia and industry. Statistical expertise must inform public policy, corporate strategy, agricultural development, financial inclusion and industrial expansion.

Fourth, champion transparent, reproducible and accessible statistics. Where figures conflict, professionals should explain why. Where methods change, they should communicate the implications. Where evidence contradicts popular assumptions, professional courage requires us to say so.

Fifth, make CISON a dependable source of independent professional advice on national questions. The Institute should help Nigerians distinguish evidence from speculation, correlation from causation, and statistical significance from practical importance.

Finally, invest in the next generation. Mentor young statisticians, expand opportunities for women and underserved communities, and make the profession attractive to the brightest minds in our universities.

The Institute's charter gives it an important mandate. The quality of its leadership will determine how fully that mandate translates into national value.

CONCLUSION: FROM COUNTING TO CONSEQUENCE

Distinguished guests, a nation's statistics should ultimately tell a human story.

Behind every poverty figure is a household seeking dignity. Behind every employment statistic is a person searching for opportunity. Behind every school enrolment number is a child whose future depends on the quality of learning. Behind every fiscal indicator is a decision that can either improve or diminish human welfare.

Our responsibility is to ensure that the numbers lead to better decisions, and that better decisions lead to better lives.

As Nigeria pursues economic transformation under President Bola Ahmed Tinubu, we must build a country that measures progress honestly, corrects its failures courageously and deploys evidence intelligently.

To CISON, I say: your first fifty years established the legacy. Let the next fifty establish Nigeria as a nation whose decisions are informed by credible evidence, whose institutions learn continuously, and whose development is measured not merely by what government spends, but by what citizens experience.

On this note, and in celebration of fifty years of professional service and the promise of a more data-driven Nigeria, I hereby declare open the 3rd International Conference and Golden Jubilee Celebration of the Chartered Institute of Statisticians of Nigeria.

I wish you fruitful deliberations and a renewed commitment to statistical excellence in the service of our nation.

Thank you, and God bless the Federal Republic of Nigeria.